SIR KENELM DIGBY ON 'FOLIE A DEUX'. AN HISTORICAL NOTE

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I... pray you to remember, that when two Lutes, or two Harps, near one another, both set to the same tune, if you touch the strings of the one, the other consonant harp will sound at the same time, though no body touch it....

SIR KENELM DIGBY, 1658

The interesting phenomenon of one person inducing mental illness in another is not uncommon, but little understood, and still presents a challenge to all theories of mental illness (Greenberg, 1954).

Recognition of induced psychosis or *folie à deux* as a psychiatric picture is generally credited to the nineteenth-century French and German schools of descriptive psychiatry. Mass or epidemic psychoses had been studied historically (Hecker, 1844; Calmeil, 1845), and at first hand (Constans, 1863), but these observations did not further the delineation or understanding of clinical cases of induced psychosis.

Claims for priority

Régis (1880), describing *folie simultanée*, gave priority to Lasègue & Falret who coined the name *folie à deux* in a paper read to the Société Médico-Psychologique in 1873, published in 1877. Lasègue & Falret (1877) in turn referred only to one earlier clinical report by Dagron (1861). In a later 'rectifying note', Régis (1885) transferred priority to Baillarger (1860) who had reported 'Some examples of *folie communiquée*', and this has since been accepted in French psychiatric literature as the first clinical description. The publications of a number of other French authors, including Esquirol (1811), were ignored.

In Germany, Jörger (1888), while acknowledging the French contributions, claimed priority for his countryman Berlyn (1819) who had described mother and son sharing identical hypochondriacal delusions 'quickly healed by psychic means'. Jörger also drew attention to Hofbauer's (1846) paper on *Infectio psychica*, but neglected Ideler's (1838) discussion and case histories entitled 'Madness through the imitative instinct'. Feuchtersleben (1845) had also discussed the contagion of delusional ideas through 'pathological sympathy', and Finkelnburg (1861) described twelve cases in his major contribution 'The influence of the imitative instinct on the spread of sporadic insanity'.

The first American authors (Seguin, 1879; Kiernan, 1880; Spitzka, 1883) to describe such cases adopted the conclusions of the French. The Italians, judging from Seppilli's (1890) review, derived their views essentially from French and German writers, as did Tuke (1887, 1888) in England in his papers on 'Communicated insanity'.

Earlier English literature

All authors seem to have overlooked a great deal of relevant earlier English literature. Whytt (1764) wrote that 'there is a still more wonderful sympathy between the nervous systems of different persons, whence various motions and morbid symptoms are often transferred from one to another, without any corporeal contact or infection', which Primrose (1638) had ascribed to 'simpathy, antipathy, contagion, fascination and other such trifles'.

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Haygarth (1800) noted that 'nervous disorders are very liable to be communicated'; Prichard (1822) spoke of the multiplication 'by the influence of sympathy' of severe mental disturbances, and Millingen (1837) suggested that 'transmission of mental disease may be attributed to morbid moral and physical sympathies, which might be avoided by withdrawing the persons exposed to it from the sphere of their action'.

We will not further digress into the history of this subject here; it is our purpose to draw attention to a hitherto unnoticed account by Sir Kenelm Digby of the induction of insanity; he anticipated, indeed almost paraphrased, Lasègue & Falret's observations by more than 200 years. Digby (1603–65), writer, naval commander, diplomatist, philosopher, amateur scientist, was a member of the first Council of the Royal Society and friend of the eminent scientists and philosophers of his time.

In 1658 there appeared 'A Late Discourse made in a Solemne Assembly of Nobles and Learned Men at *Montpellier* in *France*; by Sr. *Kenelme Digby*, Knight, &c. Touching the Cure of Wounds by the *Powder of Sympathy* ...Rendred faithfully out of French into English by R. *White. Gent.*' The 'Powder of Sympathy, doth naturally, and without any Magick, cure wounds without touching them.' It was only necessary to soak bandages from the wound in a solution of the powder. Meantime 'I advise you to cast away all your playsters, onely keep the wound clean, and in a moderate temper, twixt heat and cold'—to an aseptic age sufficient explanation of its efficacy. Digby, however, was at pains to explain its action by an exposition of the nature of 'sympathy' in its physical and psychological connotations, and here the relevant passage occurs.

Lasègue & Falret concluded that: the 'active' partner being more intelligent or in a position of authority, creates the delusions and imposes them on the 'passive' subject or subjects; an isolated and prolonged intimacy seems necessary. Heredity does not supply an overall explanation. Delusions are more likely to be accepted in so far as they are plausible and play on the hopes and fears of the passive subject; often they are accepted only after a fruitless and exhausting struggle to restore the sanity of the person primarily ill: 'the indifferent escape both this useless travail and its consequences'. The prognosis for secondarily affected individuals is invariably good.

Sir Kenelm Digby's account

All these observations are contained in Digby's account:

> Now lets consider how the strong imagination of one man doth marvailously act upon another man, who hath it more feeble and passive. We see dayly, that if a person gape, those who see him gaping, are excited to do the same. If one come perchance to converse with persons that are subject to excesse of laughter, one can hardly forbear laughing, although one doth not know the cause why they laugh.* If one should enter into a house, where all the World is sad, he becomes melancholy.... Women and Children being very moist and passive, are most susceptible of this unpleasing contagion of the imagination. I have known a very melancholy woman, which was subject to the disease called the Mother,† and while she continued in that mood, she thought her self possessed, and did strange things, which among those that knew not the cause, passed for supernatural effects, and of one possessed by the ill spirit: she was a person of quality, and all this happened, because of the deep resentment she had for the death of her Husband: She had attending her four or five young Gentle-

* Cf. Bacon (1627): '*Motions* passe from one Man to another, not so much by Exciting Imagination; as by Imitation; Especially if there be an Aptness or Inclination before. Therefore *Gaping*, or *Yawning*, and *Stretching*, doe passe from Man to Man.... So that if another be apt and prepared to doe the like, he followeth by the Sight of another. So the *Laughing* of another maketh to *Laugh*.'

† 'The disease called the Mother' was thought to be caused by noxious vapours arising from the matrix or uterus, sometimes even by that organ straying from its appointed place as into the throat in 'Suffocation of the mother'. The concept is still current in psychiatric terminology under its Greek name hysteria.

women, whereof some were her Kinswomen, and others served her as Chambermaids. All these came to be possessed as she was, and did prodigious actions. These young Maids were separated from her sight, and communication, and as they had not yet contracted such profound roots of the evil, they came to be all cured by their absence; and this Lady was also cured afterwards by a Physitian, which purged the atrabilious humours, and restored her matrix to its former estate, there was neither imposture, or dissimulation in this.

I could make a notable recital of such passions that happened to the Nunnes at *Lodun*; but... I will forbear speaking thereof at this time, otherwise then to pray you to remember, that when two Lutes, or two Harps, near one another, both set to the same tune, if you touch the strings of the one, the other consonant harp will sound at the same time, though no body touch it, whereof *Galileo* hath ingeniously rendred the reason.

Further

all the effects of a strong and vehement imagination working upon another more feeble, passive, and tender, ought to be more efficacious in the Mother acting upon her son, then when the imaginations of other persons act upon them who are nothing to them.

Some contemporary observations

Among Digby's learned contemporaries, the immortal Harvey (1651) had noted in passing the sharing of delusions: 'a noble lady who had borne more than ten children... being married to a second husband, she considered herself pregnant, forming her judgement not only from the symptoms on which she usually relied, but also from the movements of the child, which were frequently felt both by herself and her sister, who occupied the same bed with her. No arguments of mine could divest her of this belief. The symptoms depended on flatulence and fat'. The prolific Robert Boyle (1663) wrote 'it often enough happens, that when a Woman is in a Fit of the *Mother*, another Hysterical person standing by, is by reason of a peculiar Disposition of her Body, soon infected with the like strange discomposure'. The theologian and classical scholar Casaubon (1655) had suggested 'that learned Naturalists and Physicians may... consider... Whether it be probable or possible, that naturall Ecstasies and Enthusiasmes, such as proceed from naturall causes merely, should be contagious: though not contagious in the same manner as the Plague, or the Pox is; yet contagious in their kind'; at the same time he firmly upheld the reality of demoniacal possession. The more enlightened and observant Digby denied the influence of 'supernatural effects' and possession 'by the ill spirit', and substituted a psychopathology. How advanced his views were can be seen from the fact that six years after his lecture the expert medical evidence of Sir Thomas Browne sent two women to the gallows for witchcraft. Even the great Willis (1667) writing on 'The Pathology of the Brain and Nervous Stock' stressed 'that very oftentimes most admirable passions are produced in the humane body, by the delusions of the Devill... by some means he enters himself into the humane body', though he is not 'presently or allways to be brought upon the stage'.

Summary

Attention is drawn to Sir Kenelm Digby's description of the condition now known as induced psychosis or *folie à deux* more than 200 years before Baillarger, and Lasègue and Falret, to whom priority is generally ascribed.

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